

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

7-0 (A)

Red 12/4/00 upl

NEW STATE RECORD _____ UNUSUAL RECORD _____

Species: Lesser Black-backed Gull (*Larus fuscus graellsii*)**Date:** 3 December 2000**Number seen:** one**Sex:** ?**Plumage:** Def. Basic**Locality:** ~~unnamed reservoir~~ ^{Taylor Lake} just east of and below Arvada Res.**Elevation:** about 5850'**Nearest town:** Arvada**County:** Jefferson**Time observed:** about 12:00 - 12:05 MST**Duration of observation:** about 15 minutes

Description: While conducting a waterbird count at this reservoir, I found an adult Lesser Black-backed Gulls (LBBG) among the many Ring-bills and Californias (CAGU). I got to see it perched and in flight.

The bird was a large, white-headed gull, larger than nearby CAGUs, but smaller than a nearby Herring Gull (HERG). The bird's head was white with extensive dark brown streaking, particularly around the yellow eyes, though this bird's streaking wasn't as heavy as that on most LBBGs in Definitive Basic. The bill was about as long as that of a nearby CAGU, but was much thicker, with somewhat of a gonydeal angle, and a very large red gonydeal spot. The mantle was darker gray than that of the nearby CAGUs, but was not, by any stretch of the imagination, black. There was a strong contrast from mantle color to wingtip color as the latter were black. The wingtip projection beyond the tail was about equivalent to that of the nearby HERG - the bird was still growing P10, so the projection was shorter than it would have otherwise been. The wingtips were extensively black, much more so than on the nearby adult HERG, as detected while the birds were in flight. The penultimate primary did not have a white mirror, but the still-growing P10 had a medium-sized one. The white trailing edge to the wing was not particularly wide and the white primary tips and scapular and tertial crescents were relatively thin. The underparts were all white, other than some pale brown streaking on the neck. The legs were yellow.

Similar species eliminated: California Gull (CAGU) eliminated by size, mantle color, and bill size and shape. HERG (*smithsonianus*) ruled out by mantle color and leg color. Other, darker forms of HERG ruled out by size (they should be larger). Slaty-backed Gull (SBGU) eliminated by wing pattern (number of mirrors and color of secondaries, the visible parts of which should be mostly white), mantle color (the bird was not virtually black-backed), and leg color. Kelp Gull (KEGU) ruled out by bill (size and shape) and by mantle color. Great Black-backed Gull eliminated by size, leg color, and by upperparts color and pattern.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): No vocalizations heard.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing species? I have seen >85 *graellsii* LBBGs on the Great Lakes and the East Coast and >10 previously in CO, bazillions of *smithsonianus* HERGs, >125 *vegae* HERGs, 10s of 1000s of GBBGs, 1000s of CAGUs, and >75 SBGUs. I have not seen any other of the darker, Asian HERGs, nor have I seen KEGU.

Light conditions: bright, but with the sun obscured by a mountain-generated cloud in front of me and to my left

Optical equipment used: Leica 32x and Swarovski 8x42

Distance, and how estimated: estimated closest distance at about 125 meters

Other observers who saw the bird with you: Joe Bens

Other observers who saw the bird independently: none of which I am aware

If photographed, type of equipment and film: I did not photograph the bird.

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: none
none

b) after



observation:

Reporting observer: Tony Leukering

Signature:

Address: Colorado Bird Observatory, 13401 Picadilly Road, Brighton, CO 80601

Date report was written: 3 December 2000 from memory about eight hours after sighting